

THE DAILY BRIEF

SEPTEMBER 16, 2026

MARKETS & FINANCE

Stocks, crypto, and the macro tape ahead of the Fed

Bitcoin trades near \$75,900 as the Clarity Act collapses. The Senate's procedural defeat of the Clarity Act on Tuesday night — the crypto industry's marquee regulatory push of the year — has done surprisingly little damage to spot. BTC held the \$75K handle overnight (closed \$75,875 on Yahoo) and is hovering around \$75,900 mid-morning Wednesday. Bernstein says the failure is actually a *win* for stablecoin issuers because rewards on idle balances keep flowing, and analysts told The Block the market will move with rates and the dollar, not Washington. (The Block, Yahoo Finance)

The Fed will decide rates at 2pm ET today. The FOMC begins Day 2 of its September meeting and Chair Warsh is widely expected to deliver a 25-basis-point *cut*, taking the federal funds target to roughly 3.75–4.00% — the first move of 2026 after five straight holds. The SEP (dot plot) is the real event: futures are pricing another two cuts before year-end, but with Warsh having scrapped forward guidance entirely, repricing risk lives in the press conference, not the statement. Watch inflation language. (SmartCalendars, Stockwirex)

Circle's Arc mainnet is live with BlackRock and Visa as validators. Circle completed the 10 billion ARC token genesis mint and brought its institutional L1 online this week, anchored by BlackRock, Visa, and a roster of TradFi names. It's the most ambitious move yet by a stablecoin issuer into the base-layer race, and it lands the same week the Clarity Act died. The timing is loud: while Congress fumbles, the rails are being built. (The Block)

German banks pile into crypto custody. Deutsche Bank confirmed plans to launch European digital-asset custody this year, supporting bitcoin, ether, and select stablecoins for institutional clients. With Circle building on BlackRock and Visa's backing, and now a systemically important German bank adding custody rails, the institutional plumbing for the next leg of crypto adoption is being laid faster than the headlines suggest. (The Block)

Robinhood engineers charged with front-running on Hyperliquid. DOJ charged two former Robinhood engineers with taking positions in tokens ahead of the platform's public listing announcements between 2025 and 2026. The case is small in dollar terms but symbolically large: it tells retail platforms that insider-trading rules from TradFi are arriving, ready or not, onchain. (DOJ / The Block)

AI & TECH

The labs, the lawsuits, the launchpads

OpenAI, Anthropic, and Google have been holding private AI safety talks for weeks. OpenAI confirmed extended cross-lab conversations with Anthropic and Google DeepMind on safety practices — even as the Trump administration publicly dismisses safety concerns and frames the race as one of pace against China. The three labs talking to each other

while Washington postures is the most concrete signal in months that the frontier-tier players see coordination as in their mutual interest. (TechCrunch)

Jensen Huang: "We don't need AI regulation — leave safety to us." Nvidia's CEO went on record Tuesday arguing AI is "just hardware and software," not an "alien mind," and that each product maker can engineer safety directly. It's a deliberate libertarian-leaning framing aimed at the EU and any U.S. state legislature eyeing frontier-model rules. Coming from the company selling the picks-and-shovels to every frontier lab, the message lands harder than if it came from a model vendor. (TechCrunch)

U.S. data centers will burn more natural gas than Germany and Japan combined by 2035. That's the projection buried in Tuesday's reporting on the AI infrastructure boom. The collision with cities scarred by heavy industry — Philadelphia is the latest flashpoint, with proposed construction next to a defunct refinery — is becoming the defining local-political fight of the AI buildout. (TechCrunch)

SpaceX sets Starship's first orbital attempt for September 22. Six years of suborbital hops and booster catches have led here. SpaceX will also try to deploy the first V3 Starlink satellites on the same flight, meaning a single failure mode takes out both the orbital debut and the next-gen constellation. Watch the launch window like a market event. (TechCrunch, Ars Technica)

OpenAI shipped a WhatsApp Business MCP server. A new model-context-protocol server lets AI coding agents — Claude, Cursor, Codex, ChatGPT — handle WhatsApp Business setup, message templates, testing, and troubleshooting. It's a small thing, but it's a glimpse of the agent-tool surface area expanding into a product used by tens of millions of SMBs globally. (TechCrunch)

Agility's humanoid robot now stops and squats to avoid harming human coworkers. The new Digit variant drops the safety cage requirement in warehouse settings. If it holds in real deployments, it's the first credible answer to "humanoid robots need to be physically segregated" — which has been the single biggest blocker to operating humanoids outside research labs. (Ars Technica)

The "AI graveyard" is filling up. Apple keeps delaying Siri AI, OpenAI's "super app" launch was messy, and the running list of shuttered projects keeps growing. Useful counterweight to the hype cycle: the gap between a demo and a deployed, retained, monetized product is where most of the casualties are born. (TechCrunch)

Fluxnium found a way to extract uranium from seawater — 50,000 years of fuel available. The clean-tech startup's fibers pull uranium directly out of ocean water, opening a fuel source orders of magnitude larger than terrestrial reserves. If it scales, the bottleneck on nuclear power stops being geology and starts being capital. (TechCrunch)

BRIEFLY

- < **Polymarket vs. Connecticut:** Underdog filed suit against the state to block its prediction-market crackdown. Polymarket and Coinbase are also named in Connecticut's cease-and-desist orders. (The Block)
- < **CoinEx shuts down** after 9 years, citing market slump and rising compliance costs. (The Block)
- < **Balancer** is winding down its protocol and returning the treasury to BAL holders, six months after a \$128M 2025 exploit. (The Block)

< **Standard Chartered** projects Arbitrum at \$10 by 2030 — a roughly 70-fold move from current levels on tokenization tailwinds. (The Block)

< **DOJ seeks \$61M** in crypto proceeds laundered through Binance from illicit Iranian oil sales. (The Block)

< **Google, OpenAI, Anthropic** three-way safety talks continue as Gemini 3.8 Flash and OpenAI's upcoming Astra escalate the coding/cyber frontier. (TechCrunch)

THE TAKEAWAY

The single most important thing happening today is the FOMC decision at 2pm ET — and the *only* thing that matters is what Warsh says after. Markets have already priced a 25bp cut, so the trade is the dot plot and the press conference. If Warsh signals a clean path to two more cuts by year-end, expect rate-sensitive tech and crypto to bid; if he reiterates that inflation isn't cooperating, expect a sharp unwind of the AI-and-risky-asset bid that's held through the summer. Separately, the Clarity Act's death looks loud in the press and quiet in the tape — Circle, Deutsche Bank, and the underlying market behavior are all signaling that institutional crypto is being built whether or not Congress shows up. The onfrastructure beat the policy cycle.

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